Past simple and past continuous

Goal: To narrate past events with the past simple, to describe a longer background action with the past continuous, and to combine the two tenses with "when" and "while".

The idea in two lines: The past simple tells what happened, one finished action after another. The past continuous (was / were + verb-ing) tells what was in progress when a shorter action interrupted it.

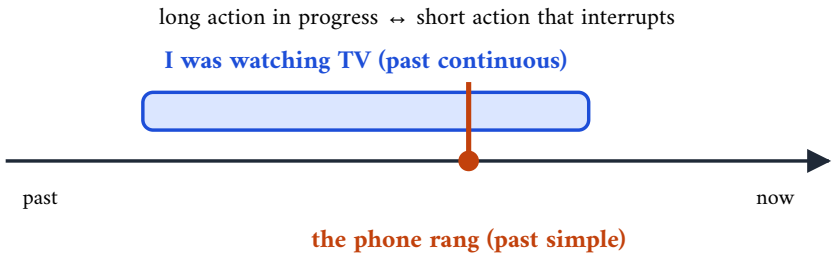


Figure 1: A long background action (continuous) interrupted by a short, finished action (simple).

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Past simple form:** regular verbs add **-ed** (play → played, stop → stopped, study → studied); irregular verbs must be learnt (go → went, see → saw, write → wrote).
2. **Past simple negatives and questions** use **did** + base verb: She didn't come. Did you see him?
3. **Past simple uses:** finished actions at a definite past time (yesterday, last week, in 2010, ago) and a sequence of events in a story.
4. **Past continuous form:** was / were + verb-ing. Negative: wasn't / weren't working. Question: Were they sleeping?
5. **Past continuous uses:** an action in progress at a past moment (At 8 o'clock I was having dinner) and the background of a story (The sun was shining, birds were singing).

6. **When / while:** "when" usually introduces the short action (past simple); "while" introduces the long action (past continuous). I was reading **when** he arrived. **While** I was reading, he arrived.

🟢 Examples

1. They (walk) home when it (start) to rain. **Answer:** were walking / started. **Explanation:** walking was in progress; the rain interrupted it.
2. Last summer we (visit) Constantine and (take) many photos. **Answer:** visited / took. **Explanation:** two finished actions in sequence with a definite past time → past simple.
3. While my mother (cook), my brother (do) his homework. **Answer:** was cooking / was doing. **Explanation:** two long actions happening at the same time → both in the past continuous.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Using the past form after "did": "Did he went?" instead of "Did he go?"
- Adding -ed to irregular verbs: "goed", "writed", "seed".
- Choosing the wrong auxiliary: "They was playing" instead of "They were playing".
- Putting the interrupting action in the continuous: "I was sleeping when the phone was ringing" instead of "...when the phone rang".

🟡 Quick review

- Finished action, definite time, story events → past simple (-ed or irregular).
- Action in progress, background → was / were + verb-ing.
- Long action + when + short action: continuous + simple.
- While + continuous; when + simple.
- Negatives and questions in the simple: did + base verb.

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